

May, 2024

It is the month
the thirteen-year and seventeen-year cycles synchronize.
Cicada broods XIII and XIX
co-emerge
from the ground
for the first time in
221 years.

Seven states
across the Midwest and Southeast
will reverberate with cicada song
until mid-June,
when the mothers lay their eggs
on the ends
of tree branches.

The newly minted nymphs hatch
one month later.
They chew through the branches,
free-fall to the roots,
feast on sap,
then follow
their ancestral path

down
deep
into
the earth:

to burrow,
incubate,
wait.

Jupiter enters Gemini
for the first time in twelve years.
Rafah is on fire.

I rage,
make calls,
watch the videos to the end
until my cheeks burn,

knowing it is both
the most
and the least
I can do.

She gets her first loose tooth.
He gets his first pimple.

It is the month
I see my mother
look genuinely happy
in a photo
for the first time.

When the largest solar storm
since 2003
erupts above us.

We wake the kids at midnight,
run down to the riverbank—
pajamas and bare feet—
to gawk at the aurora.

They are hard to see
with the naked eye,
but strangely brilliant
through my iPhone's lens:

pink, green, gold.

We visit the Field Museum in Chicago.

We sit on a bench in front of Sue,
the world's largest
fully intact T-rex fossil.

We stare silently for
thirty minutes,
then hold up photos
of chicken skeletons,
then human skeletons,
comparing them to Sue's.

None are wildly different
from the other.

In a quiet corner
of the museum's basement
we see a mummy
with our own eyes.

She is smaller than I anticipated,
not much bigger than a large child.

I fall in love
with the wide gold wings
gilding her chest,
glinting in the late afternoon light.

I wonder
how her afterlife is going.

On a sunny Tuesday
at the Shedd Aquarium
I pet a stingray
with my bare hands.

Its skin is impossibly smooth.

Tears spring unexpectedly
when I see
the white beluga whales
somersault
through the blue water.

And again
when I realize:

my boy is crying too.

It is the month
I start taking voice lessons again.

The month I sit in the clinic
every week,
IV in my left arm,
as iron is pumped back
into my watery blood.

It is the month
I remember I love sex.

The month I bleed with the full moon.

It is not
the month we finish construction
on our house.

But it is the month
my brother—
intrepid archaeologist—
hauls away
2,500 pounds
of trash and debris,
unearthing, presenting:

the yard.

The yard where my mother
plants flowers.

Where my sister hangs
window boxes.

Where we gather on Mother's Day
with old and new loves.

And my Beloveds?

She moves back to the Rockies
and prepares to give birth again—
this time at forty-five—
weeks after her eldest
returns home from college.

The cycle begins again.

My Love up north
marks both her parents' passings:

mother ten years ago,
father this time last year.

My Dear One
hears a story stir
deep underground—
a story buried with him
after the car accident in 2000.

She sings it
back to the surface
with the cicadas.

Sings it with her whole chest
for the people,
to the cameras.

Then sings him
back to sleep
so he can finally rest.

He and I
see a prick of light
pierce our familiar dark.

We realize
maybe we have been
in a tunnel all along—

dark inside
what is, in fact,
a swelling cocoon,

not a tomb,
not the bottom of a well
as we feared.

May is the month
my nine-year-old—
blood of my blood—
takes my hand
unprompted
as we walk through the park.

The month
my five-year-old—
bone of my bone—
falls asleep on my chest,

her head heavy
on my sternum,

feet reaching
all the way

to the center
of my tibias.

(How?)

It is the month
I realize
human ashes,
viewed under a microscope,
are indistinguishable
from nebulae
seen through a telescope.

The month
the nymph surrenders.

The mother emerges.

The month
I finally wade

out
into
the river,

offering my exhausted attempts
at control—

my pretense,
my projections,
denials,
fantasies,
and waning light—

to her swift current.

At least for today.

It is the month
hope returns.

The month
I wonder
if I can write a poem.